

Chapter 44-3

Generally speaking, before marriage, when a fiancée comes to the family home, she definitely should sit and look around in her partner's room. But Xu Qingzhu didn't—she just hurriedly ate lunch with Liang Shi, then Liang Shi hastily took her away.

They basically hadn't stayed for even two hours.

And Liang Shi seemed quite well-behaved in front of her parents, just maintaining constant vigilance.

Xu Qingzhu was generally quite accurate at reading people, so this was also what puzzled her.

Why would Liang Shi be so wary?

At that time they weren't married yet, and Liang Shi wasn't as much of a scumbag as she was after marriage. She had also tried asking, "Why are you afraid to bring me home?"

Liang Shi had answered then: "My parents are quite snobbish. They wanted me to marry Lin Xingcan, but I chose you, so I'm afraid they'll hurt you."

Xu Qingzhu had been moved by that answer for a long time.

Later she discovered it was just flowers in a mirror, moon in water—all illusion.

Now that Liang Shi brought up this question, Xu Qingzhu asked: "Is there a problem?"

"A big problem." Liang Shi closed her eyes and exhaled lightly. "The photo you saw on my phone that day was of my room. All the current layout is the same. When I went in, all I felt was oppression, discomfort, and fear."

"So I have reasonable suspicions." Liang Shi said: "I'm not the Liang family's biological daughter. My mother—perhaps I should call her Mrs. Liang—is using me to set up a scheme. Although I used to be a firm materialist and believed in science, I can't overcome some people's ignorance and superstition. I suspect I became a sacrifice and will be offered up."

Actually, she had another suspicion too.

But she didn't say it.

What if they said she was cheating again?

Someone as smart as Xu Qingzhu should be able to guess it too.

Just as Liang Shi finished thinking this, Xu Qingzhu said: "Is there a possibility that the ritual is fake, but wanting to destroy you is real?"

Liang Shi: "...!!!"

Indeed, talking to smart people didn't require much effort.

"To be honest, I've suspected before that you might be your father's illegitimate daughter from outside. Your family has four children—why does your mother treat only you differently? It's very simple to ruin a person: just have them listen to everything she says and prevent them from establishing correct values, and they'll be destroyed. And your former self clearly became such a person." Xu Qingzhu said: "But your mother isn't incapable of educating children. She taught Big Brother, Second Brother, and even Wanwan¹ very well."

Liang Shi's eyes lit up, but she couldn't show it too obviously, so she just said: "Right, I only recently figured this out too."

"So I followed the trail and traced it to Yunfeng Mountain." Liang Shi said: "It just so happened that our colleague mentioned going to Yunyin Taoist Temple this week to pray for peace talismans, so I went along. That Yunyin Taoist wasn't there, so I met another fortune teller."

Liang Shi told Xu Qingzhu roughly what had happened at the temple today, omitting some content that would be troublesome for her.

As for Mrs. Qi², Liang Shi also told part of it, saying she occasionally had dreams where Mrs. Qi beat her childhood self, and that Qi Jiao was also beaten together with her, but she couldn't remember anything else.

She told Xu Qingzhu most of the story, and after understanding everything, Xu Qingzhu stared at her for a while, then patted her shoulder: "It's okay, things will get better."

Liang Shi: "....."

Was this supposed to be comfort?

Neither Liang Shi nor Xu Qingzhu wanted to open that photo again to look at it, so they spared themselves.

As for the ritual matter, they would need to ask more people and consult professionals. For now, they were also at an impasse.

But it wasn't really an urgent matter.

Liang Shi handed over the peace talisman she had obtained for her. Xu Qingzhu held it in her hand and weighed it.

Then she smiled: "Very thoughtful of you."

"I really did go to pray for peace talismans." Liang Shi said: "Asking about those things was incidental. After all, those things are in the past for me. Even if I remember them, it would just add to my troubles."

"So what if I knew the truth? Wouldn't life still have to go on as usual? But when I had my fortune told today, the person said I have a blood disaster coming."

"How serious a blood disaster?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi: "Not clear, the person didn't say."

"Then be careful recently." Xu Qingzhu said: "Wear the peace talisman."

"Didn't you never believe in these things?" Liang Shi smiled: "Science student."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After saying all this, their atmosphere returned to its usual state.

Even a bit closer than before.

Night fell, dusk gathered, and evening shadows hung low.

Liang Shi asked Xu Qingzhu what she wanted for dinner. Xu Qingzhu shook her head and said she didn't particularly want anything.

So after thinking, Liang Shi asked if she wanted to eat cake?

Xu Qingzhu: ".....That works too."

Making desserts was quite troublesome, but Liang Shi did it with ease.

Xu Qingzhu helped out in the kitchen.

Though she couldn't really help much, in this kind of busyness, both of them relaxed.

No longer thinking about those complicated matters.

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Meanwhile, in another corner of China, Taoyuan County, Taozhi Village.

The courtyard was muddy after the recent rain, and having just finished funeral arrangements, the entire yard was deathly quiet.

A girl in a blue sweater came in from outside, calling loudly: "Xinran³, are you home?"

The girl who was stroking a golden pixiu⁴ in her hand looked up: "I'm here."

The girl brought in a bowl of rice: "My mom said you'd be scared alone at night, so she sent me to keep you company. Also, you haven't eaten all day, so my mom made this for you."

"No need." Guo Xinran said: "Please thank Auntie for me. I'm fine alone, I just want some quiet."

The girl was still worried: "Really? At least take the food."

Guo Xinran smiled: "Alright."

This smile seemed rather forced to the girl.

Then the girl sighed: "So what will you do? Are you going to look for your biological parents?"

Guo Xinran nodded: "I should. All these years, I never knew I was picked up⁵."

"If your family could leave you such precious gold items, they must be wealthy people." The girl said sincerely: "If you find your biological parents, life will definitely be better than now."

Seeing her low spirits, the girl said a few more words before leaving. Before going, she repeatedly reminded her not to be sad, and if she got scared at night, to call out and she would definitely come keep her company.

Guo Xinran smiled and said nothing more.

After the girl left, Guo Xinran's expression changed. She got up and poured that bowl of mixed vegetables straight into the chicken coop, looking with disgust at everything in the courtyard.

The light in the yard was dim. She stared at the dark, looming rooftop and thought to herself: "Finally dead."

Now she could go look for her biological parents.

Footnotes:

¹ Wanwan: Liang Shi's younger sister in the Liang family

² Mrs. Qi: The woman from Liang Shi's traumatic childhood memories, her original adoptive mother

³ Xinran: A common Chinese female name, meaning "joyful"

⁴ Pixiu: A mythical Chinese creature believed to bring wealth and ward off evil spirits; golden pixiu jewelry is considered very auspicious and valuable

⁵ Picked up: Chinese euphemism for "adopted," often used when referring to abandoned children who were found and raised by others